

The GBRX X-Market, decoded

GBRX held its pre-market engagement session on 29 July 2026 and set out how it intends to buy innovation and strategic technology. It came with a lot of new vocabulary, and most of the sector will meet that vocabulary for the first time in a tender notice. Here it is on one page.

THE SUPERMARKET, IN GBRX'S OWN METAPHOR

SHOP FRONT X-Market Where you see what is available. Visibility only.	THE SUPERMARKET UDM The compliant route that does the actual buying.	THE AISLES Parts Six broad capability groupings. Proposed, not final.	GOODS ON THE SHELF UK4 notice The tender itself. What you bid for.
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THE VOCABULARY

Pre-market engagement PME	A formally noticed conversation with the market before requirements are fixed. It is not a tender, and taking part confers no advantage in a later competition.
X-Market	A single visible front door for all GBRX innovation and technology opportunities. It exists because roughly 14,600 notices sit live on the Central Digital Platform at any time, which is unworkable for a small supplier.
Utilities Dynamic Market UDM	The compliant route to market behind the shop front, under the Procurement Act 2023. Unlike a framework, it stays open to join rather than closing after one bidding round.
Competitive Flexible Procedure CFP	Overlays the UDM so each competition can be shaped to its problem. A tender might ask for a proposal, a demonstration, a prototype or a pilot, with published gates between stages.
Problem area → problem statement	A problem area can be submitted by the market or the industry. GBRX shapes and tests it, then formalises it into a problem statement. The statement is what a UK4 notice is built from.
Pathfinder	The first project that paves a route others can follow. The stated aim is to scale the pathway, not the individual project, and to leave behind reusable playbooks and governance assets.
AYA AI Incubator Accelerator	Set up to address what the rail AI action plan calls the pilot graveyard. 18 priority pathfinders are already under way, the more advanced being the integrated fares model and on-journey guidance.
Central Digital Platform CDP	The government-wide supplier registration, reached through GOV.UK One Login. Registration is a prerequisite for UDM membership, so it is worth doing now.
UK13 and UK14 notices	UK13 is the intentions notice that confirms the final structure. UK14 formally establishes the market and opens tendering.

WHAT MEMBERSHIP DOES NOT REQUIRE - No specified insurance levels simply to join - No carbon reduction plan simply to join - No social value policy simply to join Core information is asked for first and detailed assurance evidence later, when a specific competition warrants it. This is the single most SME-relevant design decision in the whole model, and the one most likely to be missed.	THE SIX THINGS GBRX ASKED THE MARKET Parts. Do the six groupings work, or is there a better cut? Access. Does the design genuinely work for SMEs? Funding and IP. Does anything here deter you from tendering? Membership. Is what is asked at entry proportionate? Problem statements. Is the format usable? Ongoing engagement. What should continue after launch?
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WHERE IT GOES NEXT

29 July Pre-market engagement session. Supplier guide and slides to follow.	7 August Market Sounding Questionnaire feedback closes. This is the open door.	UK13 notice Intentions notice confirms the final X-Market and UDM structure.	UK14 notice The market is formally established and membership opens.	First UK4 tenders Problem statements reach the shelf as live opportunities.
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FOUR THINGS YOU COULD DO THIS MONTH

- Register on the Central Digital Platform.** It is a prerequisite for membership and it takes an afternoon, not a project.
- Send feedback by 7 August.** GBRX has said the final design depends on the quality of what it gets back, and the six questions above are the ones it asked.
- Read the supplier guide when it lands** and start collating the membership evidence, even though it is not needed at entry.
- Think about who you would partner with.** GBRX was explicit that frontier capability often sits in small firms, and that consortia are expected.